

6.6 Linking Tables

Access lets you do a lot more with tables in a database rather than just create and sort data. In Access, you can relate tables in a database, and then run queries and access data from the resultant combination of tables. This changes the perspective from which you would handle data in a single table. Linking tables in Access is called 'Creating a Relationship'.

There are three types of relationships between the tables of a database in Access.

6.6.1 One-to-one

This is a rarely-used relationship since you can perform its function in the same table. For instance, in our Movie database, you can link an actor's performance to his awards field. In both the tables, the ActorID will be a unique field in both tables, and hence it will be a one-to-one relationship.

6.6.2 One-to-many

This is the most common type of relationship used in Access to link tables. Here, one field of one table can be linked to many fields in the other table. An example of this would be a link between the Actors and the Movies table. One actor may have performed in many movies, but in the case of those movies, the actor is a unique entity.

6.6.3 Many-to-many

These are complex relationships where multiple items in one table can be linked to multiple items on the other table. For this, Access creates an intermediate table called the junction table where all the information about the foreign keys and the primary keys are stored. An example would be a movie store where you can buy various movies from different vendors.

In this section, we will only be looking at a one-to-many scenario. For creating relationships, we will need to perform the following steps.